

THE GAMES BEGIN

Anticipating elections early next year, both Congress and the BJP have begun chalking out their campaign strategy

■ By Priya Sahgal

The clarion call has been sounded. The Congress and the BJP have now officially moved into campaign mode anticipating elections at the beginning of next year. Both parties had a working weekend where a rough road map for E-2009 has been chalked out, both in terms of strategy and alliances. While the BJP packed its bags and camped in Bangalore for three days, the Congress preferred the shorter version and organised a one-day meeting of the extended Congress Working Committee (CWC) in the Capital. As a Congress general secretary puts it, more than a day of discussions would only lead to petty politicking and posturing for party President Sonia Gandhi's attention.

The BJP, as the main opposition party, has a much easier task in mapping out its attack, more so with its plank of terror gaining currency with each terrorist attack. The Congress is on the defensive, not just because it's in the Government but also because of its poor track record on terror. It has hope though. The BJP has an uncanny knack of taking a winning situation and reversing it to a sure defeat because of its infighting. That, as L.K. Advani pointed out in Bangalore, is the party's biggest challenge. With the Congress facing the BJP in a direct fight in four of the six states slated for polls, the coming assembly elections would be a curtain raiser for E-2009 both in terms of strategy and morale.

Besieged by a poor showing on internal security and in harnessing rising inflation, the Congress looked for issues that could counter the BJP's campaign. As a feel-good ploy, the nuclear deal ran short on semantics but it was the best that the Manmohan Singh Government had to offer Sonia.

CONGRESS VS BJP

PRIME MINISTERIAL CANDIDATE

Manmohan Singh

L.K. Advani

STAR CAMPAIGNER

Rahul Gandhi

Narendra Modi

